



tion centres first and then jail, and a family together despite the many temptations of fame.

It is a collective of remarkable lives which have often been chronicled—Nargis and Sunil Dutt were, after all, leading actors of their times, she an independent woman who once earned more than the Big Three of Bollywood, and he an eternal risk-taker, whether it was with a one-man film or a songless desert tale. But never has it been told so intimately. Sure there is a little glossing over—would you not do the same if an errant Sanjay was your brother, and forever in a daze at critical junctures in your life? But there is an almost savage ability to endure laceration. There is Nargis' tearful letter to her resentful son, sent off to boarding school at Sanawar at 10 ("You must study hard and become a big man so that you can look after us in our old age. Be a good boy, don't give any chance to your teachers to be angry with you anytime.").

Here is Sanjay's descent into drugs at college in Mumbai. There again is an anxious mother on her deathbed telling her elder daughter to take care of Sanjay, almost prescient in its anticipation of further troubles ("See that he does not get mixed up with those silly boys again. He is too stupid in his head, he does not realise what he is doing and

enough money even to buy new school uniforms, and yet another, when their imprisoned brother's rakhi gift was Rs-2 tea tokens collected over 16 months in jail.

It is also a remarkable love story between two individuals who were wide apart and yet ultimately extremely down to earth. He, Balraj Dutt, was a refugee from Pakistan Punjab who slept at Simla Haircutting Saloon at night, in between studying at Jai Hind College, working once a week in Radio Ceylon and every day at the BEST bus depot as a checking clerk. She, Fatima Rashid, was Bollywood royalty, growing up in Chateau Marine, the woman in white for the leading filmmaker of his time (which, understandably, the girls have overlooked—she was, after all, not Mrs Dutt then), and a role model for a young nation's working women.

That they found in each other a soulmate has often been a source of wonder to people. Well, not anymore. ■

